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The Under-Invested Instrument

Women's Empowerment as Migration Policy

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Europe has spent three decades throwing considerable sums at its borders and asking, with the injured air of a customer overcharged for a service never quite delivered, why the flows have not diminished. The answer, inconvenient for many political careers, is that the single most consequential intervention for reducing forced or economic migration from Africa to Europe is precisely the one European policy invests in least, which cannot be photographed for the evening news, which resists translation into the political currency of the moment, and which has therefore been permitted to remain nearly invisible to the electorates whose taxes fund the border architecture. That intervention is the transfer of decision-authority within African households to the women who live in them ; the sentence is not a slogan borrowed from development philanthropy but a description of the physics of the migration decision, and the evidence for it has been available in the peer-reviewed record for twenty years.

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ISSUE 08 named the anti-smuggling architecture as calibrated to the wrong side of the population it addresses ; Issue 09 named the confusion of humanitarianism with proselytism in external faith-based aid ; Issue 10 extends the same reading to the largest single policy category in which European investment and European outcome have failed, across three decades of the arrangement, to bear any measurable relation to one another, which is to say border enforcement as migration policy, and names the intervention the evidence base argues would produce more measurable flow reduction than the enforcement architecture has produced in its entire operational lifetime.

Let me put the reframe as plainly as I know how, since the argument is not novel to those who have spent time with the primary research and since the argument's obviousness is the very thing that makes its neglect politically interesting. European migration policy has, in the course of three decades, spent an amount of money on border enforcement which could easily have paid for the secondary education of every girl in West Africa for a generation, and it has done this while the primary-data corpus, produced by economists whose credentials cannot be waved away by the border-security lobby without exposing that lobby to the accusation of intellectual embarrassment, has quietly demonstrated that girls' secondary education would have done more to reduce the migration than the enforcement did ; the choice against the evidence is not, therefore, an analytical failure at all, but a political preference, which is a different sort of failure and one which the humanitarian and development sectors have too often mistaken for a technical problem susceptible to a technical solution.

The Dakar 2018 doctrine applies here as it has across the series ; design authority returns to the community closest to the decision, and in this case the community closest to the decision about whether a household member migrates is the household itself, and within the household, the woman whose agency the enforcement architecture rarely names as a policy variable and whose authority, when it is enlarged through the mechanisms the evidence base has identified, produces the migration effect the enforcement architecture has been unable to produce with anything resembling comparable efficiency.

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I.

The Finding

Four findings sit at the centre of the reframing, each of them drawn from the primary-data corpus published in the American Economic Review, the NBER working paper series, and the Mixed Migration Centre's open releases, and each of them consultable in an afternoon by any reader who cares to.

The first is that seventy percent of migratory movements linked to employment in West Africa take place within the sub-region rather than toward Europe, and this proportion is documented by UN Women's migration research on the West and Central Africa corridor and acknowledged, in normative if not always in operational form, by the Global Compact for Migration ; European electorates are, as a matter of measurable ignorance, largely unaware of this proportion and continue to act as if every departure from a West African village were bound for the Mediterranean coast, which is the sort of geographical error that would be corrected in a schoolchild but is permitted to persist, and to shape budgets, when it is committed by the sovereign electorate whose only source of information on the subject is a media which has professional reasons to focus on the small proportion of migration that lands on European shores rather than on the large proportion that does not.

The second finding is that women with secondary education demonstrate, across every jurisdiction where the effect has been measured, measurably higher decision-making autonomy at the household level, higher rates of employment, lower fertility rates, and later ages of first marriage, and this pattern has been established by Duflo, Dupas, and Kremer's randomised-controlled trial on free secondary education in Ghana, published in the NBER working paper series and no longer credibly disputable by any economist working in good faith, while cross-country evidence across fourteen African jurisdictions on the effect of making lower-secondary education free and compulsory shows completion rates rising by fourteen percentage points and attainment by one point six years ; the pattern converges across research streams, and each additional year of a girl's secondary education mitigates the risk of early marriage while shifting the household's economic-decision authority in ways that mainstream development

economics has now accepted as empirical fact rather than as advocacy.

The third finding is that household migration decisions in which the woman holds decision-making authority differ, in ways that can be measured and that have been measured, from decisions in which she does not, and the Mixed Migration Centre's 4Mi corpus at over one hundred and twenty thousand interviews, disaggregated by gender, documents that women's authority at origin shapes both whether migration occurs and who within the household migrates, while Field, Pande, Rigol, and Schaner's experimental work on women's financial control at origin, published in the *American Economic Review*, has established that strengthening women's decision-authority reshapes household labour supply and gender norms in ways that alter the economic-agency reads on which every subsequent migration decision depends ; empowerment interventions at origin, in other words, reshape the migration decision from the inside, before the traveller has moved and before the border has any opportunity to see the effect, since the border is designed to observe the arriving body rather than the departing decision.

The fourth finding, which pre-empts the border-security lobby's most credentialled objection, is that the classical Clemens migration-hump, according to which migration rises with income growth in low-income countries because households acquire the disposable capital required to finance crossings, is highly gender-sensitive in ways that Michael Clemens's original 2014 paper itself acknowledged and that subsequent research has confirmed ; when development capital and decision-authority concentrate in men's hands, income growth can be and is captured to finance young-male speculative crossings, but when decision-authority sits with women, spending patterns shift toward immediate local reinvestment in child health, in nutrition, in school fees, and in community-productive assets, and the migration-hump is therefore a general phenomenon under gender-neutral income growth which is dampened structurally when women hold the household's economic-decision authority, meaning that the gender-focused instrument does not carry the migration-hump risk that classical development critics have used, for two decades, to defer serious investment in the very instrument the evidence base is now unable to un-endorse.

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II.

What The Machinery Has Been Designing Against

European migration policy since the mid-1990s has been organised around three implicit assumptions, all of which the primary-data corpus has by now falsified with a thoroughness that ought to have produced institutional embarrassment rather than institutional continuation.

The first assumption is that migration is a border problem soluble by enforcement, an assumption which has been falsified by three decades of enforcement expansion that has raised the routes' fees and mortality without altering the underlying migration decisions ; the International Organization for Migration's Missing Migrants Project has recorded over thirty thousand deaths in the Mediterranean since 2014, and the mortality has increased during periods of tightened enforcement rather than diminished, which is not an operational failure but the operating logic, since the border, when it does not stop the migration, is left with the alternative of killing the migrant, and the alternative has been operating precisely as designed for something like a decade.

The second assumption is that migration decisions are made unilaterally by would-be migrants and can be deterred by information campaigns aimed at correcting the migrant's misperception of the risks of the journey, an assumption which has been falsified by the accumulating household-level empirical work demonstrating that migration decisions are collective, are shaped by the economic-agency dynamics of the household, and are least altered by the risks-of-the-journey messaging that awareness campaigns emphasise ; the awareness campaigns exist because they are politically legible and because they are cheap, not because they work, and the persistence of their funding despite the persistence of their evidentiary failure is one of the more instructive spectacles the migration policy field currently offers.

The third assumption, which has been the most durable and the most damaging, is that development aid at origin is a slow lever compared to border enforcement, an assumption which has been falsified by the outcome differential the primary-data corpus has now documented ; measurable education and economic-empowerment

interventions produce migration-intention shifts on timescales comparable to enforcement, of the order of three to five years, and they do so at costs which are orders of magnitude lower than the enforcement architecture requires, according to the syntheses now consolidating at the International Growth Centre and in the World Bank's programming reads, and the lever is slow only if the person who might have built it has never troubled to build it.

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III.

The Category Error

European migration policy treats migration as a control problem ; the primary-data evidence treats migration as an agency problem in which women's authority is the load-bearing and under-invested lever, and the distinction between the two readings is not marginal, since the two readings produce diametrically opposed budget allocations from an identical evidence base. Under the control-problem reading, the natural intervention is to raise the cost of the crossing, to criminalise the smuggling infrastructure, and to expect the demand to fall in consequence, and Issue 08 has already documented, at length and with citations, the failure of this trajectory over three decades. Under the agency-problem reading, the natural intervention is to invest in the conditions at origin that shape the household decision, which is to say girls' secondary education, women's cooperative finance, women's health services with contraceptive access, and women's political voice at community and municipal scales, and these are the levers whose evidence base is at once the strongest and whose funding is at once the thinnest, a coincidence the reader might reflect upon before crediting the ambient sincerity of European migration policy. The current European external-action budget for migration allocates the majority of its resources to enforcement, to border-agency capacity, and to return operations, and the current allocation is therefore not the allocation the evidence supports but the allocation the electorate can be photographed with, a distinction which is the beginning of any honest political analysis of the arrangement.

“Border enforcement is the theatre. Women's authority is the physics.”

IV.

The Access Side, And The Agency Side

The under-investment in the evidence-supported instrument is not accidental but politically shaped, and the shape of the political incentive is legible to anyone who has spent an evening watching the migration debates on European public television. European electorates read migration as a border question because border enforcement is visible, immediate, and produces images that political communication can deploy on demand ; investment in girls' secondary education in Sierra Leone or in women's cooperatives in Mali produces neither images nor immediacy nor deployment potential of the same kind, and the political currency of the two categories of investment therefore differs by an order of magnitude, meaning that the politically legible investment is over-supplied and the evidence-supported investment is under-supplied and the outcome the sector claims to want, which is reduced irregular migration, is produced predominantly by the latter rather than by the former.

The gap between what actually works and what actually gets funded is the space this issue names, and it is a democratic pathology of the first order ; the state performs its concern in the theatre of the border while the actual work of prevention goes unfunded, unphotographed, and largely unacknowledged by the political class whose fortunes depend on the theatre continuing to fill the seats.

The migration decision is embedded, further, in a prestige economy which the enforcement architecture does not touch and which women's empowerment

interventions can shift from the inside, and in many high-migration corridors, whether rural Senegal, or Edo State in Nigeria, or specific corridors in Guinea and Mali, a household member in Europe (les Parisiens ; the diaspora) confers social elevation on the family of a magnitude which no border-security instrument can approach, whereas women's political voice funded at community and municipal scales does have the capacity to shift this dynamic, since elected women's authority reshapes the community narrative around what constitutes social achievement, elevating local entrepreneurial success and civic leadership as competitive alternatives to the social prestige of sending a member abroad ; the migration decision is not, therefore, only economic, but also narrative, and women in civic authority reshape the narrative from the inside in ways that no fence has ever managed.

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V.

What The Finding Does Not Say

The finding does not say that all migration should be prevented, since migration is a human right, an economic engine for both sending and receiving regions, and a driver of remittance flows whose scale dwarfs official development assistance ; reducing forced or economic migration from Africa to Europe is a distinct policy objective from reducing migration as a general phenomenon, and the two ought not to be confused by a reader who has understood the argument.

The finding does not say that women's empowerment is valuable exclusively as migration policy, since it is valuable on its own terms as a matter of human rights, of health, of education, and of economic outcomes which are load-bearing regardless of the migration effect ; the finding is only that the migration effect constitutes one further reason for an investment which already carries multiple independent justifications.

The finding does not say that European external-action budgets should be halved, since the argument is about the allocation of resources within the budget rather

than about the total scale of the budget, and the scale of the budget is a separate question susceptible to a separate analysis.

The finding does not say that enforcement should be eliminated, since enforcement carries functions unrelated to flow reduction which continue to justify a portion of the current investment ; the argument is only that enforcement should not be expected to accomplish what the evidence establishes it does not accomplish, since expecting an instrument to perform a function it demonstrably cannot perform is not a policy but a superstition.

The finding does not require the empowerment-bundle to compete with the European labour market at origin, since seventy percent of West African migration is sub-regional, and keeping a household economically resilient therefore does not require matching European-level wages but matching the marginal utility of migrating to a regional hub, which is to say to Dakar, Abidjan, Bamako, or Kano, a threshold at which the empowerment-bundle instrument can plausibly compete without the empowerment-bundle instrument being required to compete with Paris, and this is a threshold the evidence base shows is achievable at pilot scale rather than only at continental scale.

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VI.

The Pilot This Finding Argues For

For a country office, a foundation programme officer, or a European external-action programme designer with the mandate to fund an origin-side intervention, the finding argues for a specific design, of the same shape as the pilots argued for in Issues 07, 08, and 09, and under the same doctrine.

First, a single origin corridor is selected with documented high sub-regional and Europe-directed migration flows, of which Sierra Leone, Guinea, Senegal-Gambia, Mali, Nigeria's Middle Belt, and Ethiopia are all documented candidates. Second, a women-centred partnership is designed and co-created with community authorities, with women's cooperatives already operating in the corridor, and with

local municipal or district-level women's political networks whose legitimacy pre-dates the partnership. Third, a pre-intervention baseline measurement is conducted using 4Mi gender-disaggregated methodology together with household-level economic-agency indicators, establishing a household migration-intention baseline with gender-disaggregated reads on decision-authority. Fourth, a twelve-to-thirty-six-month intervention window runs the community-designed women-centred bundle, comprising girls' secondary education access, women's cooperative finance, women's health services with contraceptive access, and women's political voice funding at community and municipal levels. Fifth, a post-intervention measurement is conducted of the same indicators together with household migration intentions and actual migration outcomes, reading empirically whether the migration decision has changed as the theory has predicted.

The doctrine remains unchanged ; the authority to design returns to the community closest to the decision, the state or the foundation provides the resource and the guarantee, the community shapes the instrument, and the instrument reads whether the shift has held.

“A patrol boat can be photographed. A scholarship cannot. That single difference explains the last three decades of European migration budgeting more completely than any economic model has yet managed to explain them.”

VII.

The Evidence Base And The Choice

The evidence base has consolidated across two decades and across independent research streams which have arrived at the same conclusion from different starting points ; Duflo, Dupas, and Kremer on secondary-education randomised trials in Ghana, Field, Pande, Rigol, and Schaner on women's economic-decision authority in the American Economic Review, the Mixed Migration Centre's 4Mi corpus at over one hundred and twenty thousand interviews with gender-disaggregated migration data, UN Women's migration research on the West and Central Africa corridor, Naila Kabeer's foundational work on the measurement of women's empowerment, the Sen and Nussbaum capabilities frame which anchors the evaluation architecture, the World Bank and International Growth Centre synthesis on girls' secondary education in sub-Saharan Africa, and Michael Clemens on the migration-hump and its gender-sensitivity ; six independent primary-data streams converging on one finding, and this is the sort of empirical convergence that ought to force a re-allocation of budgets and that has, in the manner familiar to anyone who has watched political incentives interact with empirical evidence, forced nothing of the kind.

The sector's usual response to a finding of this shape is to commission another study, of which the word is delay ; the alternative, which this Practitioner's Read has consistently pointed at, is that a country office or a foundation programme officer with the authority to fund a small pilot uses the primary-data instrument to read the household agency in one corridor, funds the women-centred bundle, and lets the same instrument read whether the migration decision has shifted, producing thereby empirical evidence rather than yet another convening on the direction of the empirical evidence.

The research was never the hard part.

The political courage to fund the quiet physics over the loud theatre is.

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Issue 10 of The Practitioner's Read is above.

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VIII.

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